Aquifer Open Study Notes

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2 Timothy

2 Timothy 1:1

the promise of life: See Romans 4:13–17. This letter to Timothy celebrates Christ's resurrection and the life that comes from it (2 Timothy 2:8; 1:10). The resurrection is the solution to the suffering and death of godly people (3:12). Paul's life demonstrates this hope (4:17–18).

2 Timothy 1:1–2

See study note on 1 Timothy 1:1–2.

2 Timothy 1:3

- as did my forefathers: See Philippians 3:5; compare Deuteronomy 6:4–9.
- with a clear conscience: This might relate to heresy (false teachings or practices) (see 2 Timothy 2:17–18; see also 1 Timothy 1:5). Or it could refer to Paul's previous legal defense of himself (see Acts 23:1; 24:14–16).

2 Timothy 1:3–4

Giving thanks and prayer are common parts of Paul's letters (for example, Romans 1:8–12; Colossians 1:3–14; contrast Galatians 1:6–10).

2 Timothy 1:4

- Paul urges Timothy to visit him (see study note on 1:5–14).
- your tears: Paul and Timothy may have last parted right before the Jews arrested Paul in Jerusalem and sent him to Rome (compare Acts 20:37–38; 21:12–14).

2 Timothy 1:5

- For information on Timothy's family background, see Acts 16:1–3 and 1 Timothy 1:2.
- sincere faith: Faith here means the Christian faith. However, Timothy's Jewish heritage from his grandmother and mother shows his foundation in Old Testament teachings (2 Timothy 3:14–15). Their Christian faith served as a model for him.

2 Timothy 1:5–14

- Paul is gentle but firm in calling Timothy to come to Rome (see also 4:9, 21; compare 1 Timothy 1:3–11, 12–17). Suffering seemed certain if Timothy remained loyal. Paul wanted to strengthen Timothy's determination.
- The mentions of the Holy Spirit in 2 Timothy 1:6–7 and 1:14 create an inclusio (literary framework) around this section.

2 Timothy 1:6

- fan into flame: The Holy Spirit's work does not happen automatically. Timothy must cultivate this work with careful attention to his spiritual life (see Ephesians 5:18–21; 1 Thessalonians 5:19–20; compare Acts 4:31; 7:55; 13:9).
- the gift: This is the Holy Spirit empowering ministry (see 1 Corinthians 12:1–14:40; compare Acts 6:3, 5; 11:24).
- through the laying on of my hands: Paul and the elders ordained (official ceremony of appointment) Timothy for ministry with a ceremony that included laying on of hands (1 Timothy 4:14).

2 Timothy 1:8

This verse summarizes the letter. Timothy would probably encounter suffering both when traveling to Rome and in his later ministry as Paul's follower (2:3; 3:12; 4:5; see Hebrews 13:23).

2 Timothy 1:9–10

- This passage emphasizes the importance of suffering for the sake of the gospel and encourages Timothy toward that end (1:8; compare 1 Timothy 1:15; 2:5–6).
- He has saved us ... our Savior, Christ Jesus: God and Christ are both described as Savior (see 1 Timothy 1:1; 2:3–4).
- called us to a holy calling: Salvation and godliness are connected (see 1 Timothy 3:14–16; 5:8; Titus 2:11–14; 3:4–7; Ephesians 2:10).
- and by the grace He granted us: Grace is not given because we deserve it, but because God grants it (see Romans 3:23–24; 5:6–11; Ephesians 2:8–9; Titus 3:5).
- by His own purpose ... before time began: See Titus 1:2; John 17:24; Ephesians 1:4, 11; 1 Peter 1:20; Revelation 13:8. Salvation does not depend on human effort but only on God's grace.

2 Timothy 1:10

- he has revealed this grace: The presence of God's grace is evident in history through Christ Jesus (see Romans 16:26; 1 Peter 1:20).
- through the appearing: See study note on 1 Timothy 6:14.
- abolished death: See 1 Corinthians 15:26; 2 Thessalonians 2:8; Hebrews 2:14.

- the way to life: See 2 Timothy 1:1; 1 Corinthians 15:53–54; Titus 1:2.
- through the gospel: Christ provides salvation, but the proclaiming of the good news about Jesus is the way people receive his salvation (see Titus 1:2–3; Romans 1:16–17; 10:14–15).

2 Timothy 1:12

- Paul was confident as he encountered his own death (see 4:17–18; Romans 1:16; 2 Corinthians 4:8–9; Philippians 1:20). He set an example for Timothy to follow (see 2 Timothy 1:8).
- what I have entrusted to Him (or what has been entrusted to me; literally my deposit): The Greek phrase, my deposit, could mean either the good news about Jesus entrusted to Paul, or Paul's life and ministry that he committed to God (see 1 Timothy 6:20).

2 Timothy 1:14

Timothy must protect the important truth (literally guard the good deposit; see study notes on 1:12; 3:11). He is to do this by accurately proclaiming it and preventing false teachers from distorting it (see study note on 2:2; see also 1 Timothy 6:20).

2 Timothy 1:15

- everyone ... has deserted me: This happened either in Rome or in the province of Asia Minor when authorities arrested Paul. Paul might have considered this as another way his life followed Christ's pattern (see Matthew 26:31, 56).
- Phygelus and Hermogenes are otherwise unknown. The context might imply that they were church leaders who sided with the opponents of Paul (2 Timothy 1:11–14).

2 Timothy 1:15–18

Paul encourages Timothy to remain loyal and to come to Rome without fear. He mentions both good and bad examples from others.

2 Timothy 2:1

You, therefore, my child: In Greek, the word therefore connects this phrase to 1:15–18. The use of you as a directive emphasizes that Timothy's life should stand in contrast with the previous examples.

2 Timothy 2:1–13

Timothy is again told to be strong and endure suffering with Paul (2:1–7; see 1:8). Timothy should find motivation in the good news about Jesus and in Paul's example (2:8–13).

2 Timothy 2:2

- many witnesses: Reliable witnesses would confirm the truth of Paul's teaching (see also 3:10–11).
- entrust these: The verb entrust is related to the word deposit (see study notes on 1:12, 14). Timothy's task of guarding the deposit includes entrusting it to faithful men.

2 Timothy 2:4–7

Paul quickly quotes a series of sayings about hard work, struggle, and reward.

2 Timothy 2:8

Jesus Christ, descended from David, resurrected from the dead (see Romans 1:3–4). It's important to understand suffering with Christ from the point of view of future resurrection.

2 Timothy 2:8–13

The apostle Paul's suffering is an extension of the suffering of Jesus Christ. It emphasizes the crucifixion and resurrection as the core of the good news about Jesus (1:12; see also 1:8). Paul's suffering, like Christ's, helped bring salvation to others. Christ approves of those who suffer and endure with him.

2 Timothy 2:9

- like a criminal: Paul identified with the death of Jesus (2:11; Philippians 3:10–11).
- the word of God cannot be chained: Both Paul and the good news about Jesus would be victorious through the power of Christ's resurrection (see 2 Timothy 4:17–18; see also 2 Corinthians 12:8–10; Philippians 1:12–14).

2 Timothy 2:11

a trustworthy saying: See study notes on 1 Timothy 1:15 and 2:5–6.

2 Timothy 2:13

He remains faithful: This could mean that:

1. he gives those who have sinned a chance to ask God for forgiveness;
2. he judges non-Christians in truth according to his will that never changes;
3. he acts as a true example for his people to follow; and/or

4. he will achieve his purposes in history. He will save those who trust in him through the good news about Jesus (1:12; 2:19). See also Romans 3:3–4; 1 Corinthians 10:13; 1 John 1:9.

2 Timothy 2:14–26

Timothy must focus on Paul's teaching and avoid the teachings and behavior of false teachers 2:8–13. The false teachings were probably similar to those in 1 Timothy 6:20–21.

2 Timothy 2:15

accurately handles the word of truth: The Berean Standard Bible connects this verse to interpreting the gospel teachings correctly. Another possibility is that the apostle Timothy should remain focused on his teaching ministry and avoid getting involved in the arguments of false teachers (see 1 Timothy 1:4; 2 Timothy 2:16).

2 Timothy 2:17

- Hymenaeus previously worked with Alexander (1 Timothy 1:20). Both men continued to cause trouble through false teaching (2 Timothy 4:14–15).
- Philetus became Hymenaeus's new teaching partner.

2 Timothy 2:18

They say that the resurrection has already occurred: Compare 2 Thessalonians 2:2. These false teachers might have distorted Paul's teachings on resurrection (Romans 6:5; Galatians 2:20; Ephesians 1:3; 2:6; 5:14; Colossians 2:12; 3:1–4). They perhaps taught that people already fully participated in the life of heaven and that physical resurrection would not happen. They might have believed that a person's actions in the body did not matter because bodies that die cannot affect eternal spirits.

Or perhaps they may have practiced extreme self-denial (1 Timothy 4:3; see Colossians 2:8, 16–23). They might have thought that enjoying material things was wrong for spiritual beings. These teachers might have interpreted the teachings of Jesus to mean he banned marriage (Matthew 19:10–12; 22:30; 1 Timothy 4:3). Their perspectives on Old Testament law might have led them to promote certain things banned (1 Timothy 1:7–11). They might have been too aggressive in promoting equality (see 2 Tim 3:6; compare Galatians 3:28; 1 Timothy 2:11–15).

They might have held to the belief that the future age had already arrived. Their teachings might have focused only on resurrection power, opposing Paul's message of suffering and Christ's crucifixion (see 2 Timothy 1:8, 12; 2:8–13; compare 1 Corinthians 4:8–13; 2 Corinthians 12:8–10). Paul describes their teachings as "irreverent, empty chatter" (2 Timothy 2:16).

2 Timothy 2:19

- Paul assures Timothy that false teachings will not succeed. He emphasizes the importance of being pure (see 3:9).
- firm foundation: This metaphor emphasizes safety from destruction (Isaiah 28:16). It may suggest a temple (see also 1 Timothy 3:15; 1 Corinthians 3:11; Ephesians 2:20; 1 Peter 2:4–7; Revelation 21:14).
- The Lord knows: This quote refers to Numbers 16:5.
- "Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord must turn away from iniquity": See Isaiah 52:11; compare Numbers 16:26–27; Leviticus 24:16; Psalm 6:8.

2 Timothy 2:20–21

Building on 2:19, the apostle Paul uses imagery of vessels in a wealthy home (see Romans 9:21). In God's household, Christians should strive to be like a valuable and useful vessel, not a cheap or useless one.

2 Timothy 2:22

- those who call on the Lord: Compare Psalm 99:6; Joel 2:32; Acts 2:21; 9:14, 21; 22:16; Romans 10:12–13; 1 Corinthians 1:2.
- out of a pure heart: See 1 Timothy 1:5.

2 Timothy 2:24

- a servant of the Lord: See Titus 1:1; compare with Isaiah 42:1–2; 50:6; 53:7; Matthew 12:14–21.
- must be ... able to teach, and forbearing: See 1 Timothy 3:2–3; Titus 3:2.

2 Timothy 2:25

gently reprove: Compare 1 Corinthians 4:21; 2 Corinthians 10:1; 1 Thessalonians 5:14; 2 Thessalonians 3:14–15; Titus 3:10–11; Jude 1:22–23.

2 Timothy 3:1–5

Paul explains how people will behave in the last days, which had already started (see also 1 Timothy 4:1–5; 2 Peter 2:1–22; 3:3; Jude 1:18; 2 Timothy 3:5, 6–9).

2 Timothy 3:1–4.8

Timothy must remain focused during the difficult times ahead.

2 Timothy 3:5

such as these: These people rejected good teaching. They denied the power that could make them live as God desires (3:2–4; see 1 Timothy 1:5–11; Colossians 2:16–23).

2 Timothy 3:6–7

The letters to Timothy and Titus consistently express concern about the impact of false teachers on households and women (Titus 1:11; see 1 Timothy 2:11–15; 3:4–5; 5:14–15). Whether or not these false teachers specifically targeted women, they were successful with some.

2 Timothy 3:8

According to tradition, Jannes and Jambres are the names of the Egyptians who opposed Moses and practiced magic (see Exodus 7:8–13; 8:18; 9:11).

2 Timothy 3:11

- Timothy was from Lystra, near Antioch and Iconium, so he knew about Paul's suffering (see Acts 13:14, 45–51; 14:1–8, 19–22). Paul recruited him after these events had happened (Acts 16:1–3).
- the Lord rescued me: Paul could confirm from his own life that the Lord would fulfill his plans through his loyal servant (see 2 Timothy 4:6–8, 17–18; Psalm 22:19–22; 34:19; Daniel 3:17–18; 2 Corinthians 1:8–10; 2 Peter 2:7–9).

2 Timothy 3:14–15

- From childhood, Timothy's Jewish grandmother and mother, Lois and Eunice, taught him the Old Testament Scriptures (see Acts 16:1–3; see 2 Timothy 1:5). Their lives reinforced their teachings.
- the Holy Scriptures, which are able to make you wise ... in Christ Jesus: The Old Testament Scriptures give people the wisdom to receive Christ. At the same time, understanding Jesus Christ is necessary to fully understand the Old Testament Scriptures.

2 Timothy 3:16

- All Scripture is God-breathed: This means it comes directly by God's own speech (see also Hebrews 4:12–13; 2 Peter 1:20–21). This does not remove the role of human authors. It confirms that God is fully responsible for his word, and that scripture is true, reliable, and has authority. It is permanent and powerful because it comes from God. Its message is plain and consistent about Jesus Christ (see Luke 24:25–27, 44; John 5:39–40; Acts 3:24; 1 Corinthians 15:3–4). It has the power to bring salvation and inspire true faith. People must not abuse it, as some false teachers have done (2 Timothy 4:2–4; 1 Timothy 1:4–7; compare 2 Peter 3:16). But God's leaders must teach it correctly (2 Timothy 2:2, 15).
- As a result of its inspiration from God, all Scripture is useful. Both the Old Testament and the New Testament together guide and teach Christians in this life.

2 Timothy 3:16–17

These verses expand on 3:15 by explaining Scripture's effectiveness, its source, and how it provides wisdom for practicing the life of salvation. Paul was referring to the Old Testament. But his statement now applies to all Scripture, including the New Testament (see, for example, 2 Peter 3:15–16).

2 Timothy 3:17

Paul explains that salvation leads to living the way God desires (3:15; see Galatians 1:4; 5:16–26; Ephesians 2:8–10).

2 Timothy 4:1

- judge the living and the dead: See Matthew 25:31–46; Acts 10:42; Romans 14:7–12; Revelation 20:11–15.
- His appearing: See study note on 1 Timothy 6:14; see also 2 Timothy 1:10; 4:8; Titus 2:11–13; 3:4.

2 Timothy 4:1–8

Timothy's ministry truly existed in the presence of God and of Christ Jesus. Paul commanded him to work, expecting the return of Jesus to judge and establish his kingdom (see 1 Timothy 5:21; 6:13–14).

Christ's appearing will bring:

- spiritual cleaning (2 Timothy 2:19),
- accountability (3:8–9),
- salvation,
- declaration of righteousness, and
- reward (4:8, 18).

See also 1 Corinthians 3:10–15; 4:4–5; 2 Corinthians 5:10.

2 Timothy 4:5

This final statement summarizes the earlier points (1:6–14; 2:1–15, 24–26; 3:12).

2 Timothy 4:5–8

Paul gives some final leadership instructions and a testament to Timothy (compare Deuteronomy 31:7–8; 34:9; 2 Kings 2:1–18).

2 Timothy 4:6

being poured like a drink offering: Paul regards his death as a sacrifice to God (see Exodus 29:40–41; Leviticus 23:13; Numbers 28:7; Philippians 2:17). This offering participates in Christ's own sacrifice (see Colossians 1:24; see also Romans 12:1).

2 Timothy 4:6–8

Paul's faithfulness, right standing with God, and reward are a model and a challenge to others (particularly Timothy) to follow Paul's example after he is gone.

2 Timothy 4:7

Paul remained true to the trust (literally, "deposit") committed to him (see study notes on 1:12; 1 Timothy 6:20; compare Acts 20:24). He kept the integrity of the Christian faith and commanded Timothy to do the same (see 2 Timothy 2:3–7; 1 Timothy 1:18; 6:12; compare Romans 15:30–31; 1 Corinthians 9:25–27; Hebrews 12:1; Jude 1:3).

2 Timothy 4:8

- crown of righteousness: being declared righteous at the time of judgment was the only thing that remained for Paul (see also James 1:12; 1 Peter 5:4; Revelation 2:10; 3:11).
- If we live expecting that Christ will return, we will eagerly look forward to His appearing to establish his kingdom (see 1 Timothy 6:14; 2 Timothy 4:1). If we do not follow Christ's commands, we will not welcome his appearing, because it will be as Judge.

2 Timothy 4:9

Paul plainly commands Timothy to come to Rome (see 1:4).

2 Timothy 4:10

- Demas: See Colossians 4:14; Philemon 1:24.
- deserted: Also see 2 Timothy 4:16–17; compare Psalm 22:1; Mark 15:34.
- love of this world: This contrasts with awaiting Christ's glorious return (2 Timothy 4:8).
- Crescens is otherwise unknown. The absence of Crescens and Titus seems to have increased Paul's isolation.
- Titus was Paul's effective and reliable fellow worker. He might have gone to Dalmatia (northwest of modern-day Greece) on a mission for Paul.

2 Timothy 4:11

- Luke: The author of the Gospel of Luke and the book of Acts traveled with Paul at different times. Many believe Luke was Paul's physician (Colossians 4:14). Luke was the only one of Paul's fellow workers who stayed with him continually. Therefore, Paul wanted Timothy to come quickly.
- Mark: Paul's belief that Mark would be useful shows a Christian story of amending differences (see Acts 13:13; 15:36–40; see also Colossians 4:10; Philemon 1:24).

2 Timothy 4:12

Tychicus was apparently a Greek from Asia Minor (implied in Colossians 4:7–8, 10–11); see also Acts 20:4; Ephesians 6:21–22; Colossians 4:7–8; Titus 3:12). He was possibly going to Ephesus to deliver the letter and replace Timothy, assuming Timothy was in Ephesus.

2 Timothy 4:13

- Paul's arrest and transfer to Rome apparently prevented him from gathering his possessions.
- the cloak: Winter was approaching (4:21).
- Carpus might have hosted Paul in Troas. Mentioning Troas suggests Timothy was still in Ephesus and would travel through Troas, a port town.
- my scrolls, especially the parchments: These writings may have included Scriptures, personal notes, letters to Paul, copies of Paul's own letters, and other Christian and Jewish materials.

2 Timothy 4:14

- Alexander was a common name (see Mark 15:21; Acts 4:6; 19:33). Alexander the coppersmith was probably the same person mentioned in 1 Timothy 1:20.
- did great harm to me: He probably did more than just oppose Paul's teaching. He might have been part of Paul's arrest.

2 Timothy 4:16

- At my first defense: A Roman trial had two parts, a preliminary investigation and the main trial. Paul was probably talking about the first part. It might also refer to his first time in prison at Rome (Acts 28; see 2 Timothy Book Introduction, "Date of Writing").
- everyone deserted me: See study note on 2 Timothy 4:10.

2 Timothy 4:17

- so that through me the message would be fully proclaimed: Paul used his defense in court to share the good news about Jesus, similar to his past expe-

riences (Acts 22:1–24:27; 26:1–29; see also 2 Timothy 2:9–10; Philippians 1:12–14).
- all the Gentiles would hear it: Paul felt he had finished his mission (2 Timothy 4:7–8). The Old Testament prophesies the conversion of nations (for example, Psalm 22:27–29).
- from the mouth of a lion: The lion often symbolizes enemies (see Psalms 7:2; 35:17; compare Daniel 6; Hebrews 11:33). Here, it might mean:
- literal lions in the Roman theaters,
- the emperor,
- false teachers, or
- Satan (1 Peter 5:8; compare Psalm 22:21).

2 Timothy 4:18

- God would continue to strengthen Paul and keep him strong in faith until the end of his life (4:7; see 1:12).
- The Lord's heavenly kingdom is different from this kingdom of earth that was about to judge Paul (see also 4:1; 1 Corinthians 15:48–49; Hebrews 12:18–29).
- glory … Amen: Paul's praise of God, even when facing death, shows his belief that God's glory will remain (compare 1 Timothy 1:17; 6:15–16).
- to Him: The Greek text implies this praise is for "the Lord" in the previous sentence, specifically referring to Jesus (compare Titus 2:13).

2 Timothy 4:19

- Prisca and Aquila were probably in Ephesus at this time (Acts 18:26; 1 Corinthians 16:19). They also lived in Rome, where Paul currently was (Acts 18:2; Romans 16:3). This suggests that Timothy might still be in Ephesus (see 1 Timothy 1:3).
- Paul is grateful when mentioning Onesiphorus in 2 Timothy 1:16 for helping him while he was in prison.

2 Timothy 4:19–21

Like in many of Paul's letters, this one ends with greetings and final instructions (for example, Romans 16:1–23; 1 Corinthians 16:19–21; 2 Corinthians 13:12).

2 Timothy 4:20

- Erastus lived in Corinth (Acts 19:22; Romans 16:23). Modern archaeological digs found an inscription (carved writing) in Corinth mentioning an Erastus who was the city treasurer. He was probably the same man.
- Trophimus was an Ephesian connected with Tychicus (Acts 20:4; 21:29; 2 Timothy 4:12).

2 Timothy 4:21

- before winter: Paul probably worried about a long delay if Timothy missed the chance to travel in the fall (see 1:4; 4:9). Winter weather interrupted travel across the Adriatic Sea from November to March (see Acts 27:12). Paul might also have been eager to receive his cloak for the cold prison (2 Timothy 4:13). The New Testament does not mention Eubulus elsewhere. But he was obviously well-known to Timothy.
- Pudens was a name used by upper-class families.
- Linus: Both the bishop Eusebius and the bishop Irenaeus later identified Linus as the first bishop of Rome.
- The New Testament does not mention Claudia elsewhere.
- brothers: Greek adelphoi, a term for family members, both male and female.

2 Timothy 4:22

- The unique phrasing here might emphasize what Paul already mentioned in 1:6–8 and 2:1 (compare Galatians 6:18, Philippians 4:23, and Philemon 1:25).
- with you all: Paul intended that Timothy would read this letter in public.